LONDON, UNITED KINGDOM

# National Gallery: Masterpieces

Twenty works that bring a scene close, hold it at a distance or unsettle its viewpoint.



A mirror enlarges the room in the *Arnolfini Portrait*. In *The Ambassadors*, a shape on the floor becomes a skull only from an oblique angle. Elsewhere, a basket approaches the edge of a supper table, a horse has almost no background, and a locomotive advances along a bridge that weather threatens to obscure. These paintings do not all offer the spectator the same kind of place.

This selection follows that difference. Some images give a firm position from which to look; others complicate it. The point is not to find a hidden trick in every work, but to notice how the space of a picture affects the encounter it permits.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

## Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context  Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-gallery-london

# The selection · 20

1. The Arnolfini Portrait
   Jan van Eyck · 1434
2. The Ambassadors
   Hans Holbein the Younger · 1533
3. The Fighting Temeraire
   J. M. W. Turner · 1839
4. Sunflowers
   Vincent van Gogh · 1888
5. Bacchus and Ariadne
   Titian · 1520-3
6. The Supper at Emmaus
   Caravaggio · 1601
7. The Hay Wain
   John Constable · 1821
8. The Baptism of Christ
   Piero della Francesca · probably about 1437–1445
9. Whistlejacket
   George Stubbs · 1762
10. The Execution of Lady Jane Grey
    Paul Delaroche · 1833
11. A Young Woman Standing at a Virginal
    Johannes Vermeer · about 1670-2
12. Rain, Steam, and Speed — The Great Western Railway
    J. M. W. Turner · 1844
13. Christina of Denmark
    Hans Holbein the Younger · c. 1538
14. Christ in the House of Mary and Martha
    Diego Velázquez · c. 1620
15. Allegory of Love: Respect
    Paolo Veronese · c. 1575
16. Bacchanal before a Statue of Pan
    Nicolas Poussin · 1631 - 1633
17. Banks of the Seine at Port-Marly
    Alfred Sisley · 1875
18. The Building of the Trojan Horse
    Giovanni Domenico Tiepolo · 1760
19. Dutch Boats in a Gale
    J. M. W. Turner · 1801
20. The Doge Visiting the Church and Scuola di San Rocco
    Canaletto · c. 1735

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# The Arnolfini Portrait

Jan van Eyck

1434 · Oil on wood · National Gallery



Jan van Eyck. The Arnolfini Portrait. Image credit: Jan van Eyck; Source credit: Web site of National Gallery, London. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The small mirror extends the room beyond what is directly shown, including additional figures behind the main pair. That detail changes the scale of the spectator’s knowledge. Van Eyck’s close description does not simply fill an already complete scene; it supplies a second view that makes the first one less self-contained.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG186

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# The Ambassadors

Hans Holbein the Younger

1533 · National Gallery



Hans Holbein the Younger. The Ambassadors. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The shelves display instruments and books clearly, but the pale form near the men’s feet demands another position from which to be seen. Viewed obliquely, it resolves into a skull. Holbein makes that reminder of death incompatible with the straightforward view of status and learning: the spectator cannot hold every part of the portrait equally in focus.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

# The Fighting Temeraire

J. M. W. Turner

1839 · National Gallery



J. M. W. Turner. The Fighting Temeraire tugged to her last berth to be broken up. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The pale sailing ship and the dark, smoking tug occupy very different conditions of light. The tug performs the practical action while the larger vessel seems less solid against the sky. Across the water, sunset gives another broad area of brightness. Turner makes the contrast between the ships visible before it is translated into a story of change.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Sunflowers

Vincent van Gogh

1888 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery




Still Life - Vase with Fifteen Sunflowers. WikiArt; Vincent van Gogh. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Several flower heads have lost the open form others retain. Within vase, background and petals, yellow changes enough to distinguish those conditions without a wide palette. The bouquet is therefore not a row of equivalent blooms. Its drooping heads and exposed centres give difference and duration a place inside a closely restricted colour arrangement.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Bacchus and Ariadne

Titian

1520-3 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



Titian. Bacchus and Ariadne. Image credit: Titian; Source credit: National Gallery, London - online catalogue .. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

Bacchus’s feet leave the ground as Ariadne turns between his approach and the departing ship. The gap beneath him makes the encounter a suspended instant rather than a settled pair of poses. His flying cloak extends the leap across the sky, while the other directions of movement keep the moment from belonging to him alone.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG35

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# The Supper at Emmaus

Caravaggio

1601 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



Caravaggio. The Supper at Emmaus. Image credit: Caravaggio; Source credit: Self-scanned. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

An extended arm and the basket near the table’s edge push the scene toward the spectator. The food remains ordinary and tangible, while the figures’ reactions change what the meal has become. Recognition is given a bodily form: the arrangement of hands and arms registers an event that cannot be explained by the still life alone.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG172

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# The Hay Wain

John Constable

1821 · National Gallery



John Constable. The Hay Wain. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The wagon belongs to the shallow water and the work of the surrounding land, rather than being placed in front of a separate landscape. Trees shelter the cottage side of the view, making the field beyond appear more open. Constable connects these spaces through light and passage, keeping both enclosure and distance available.

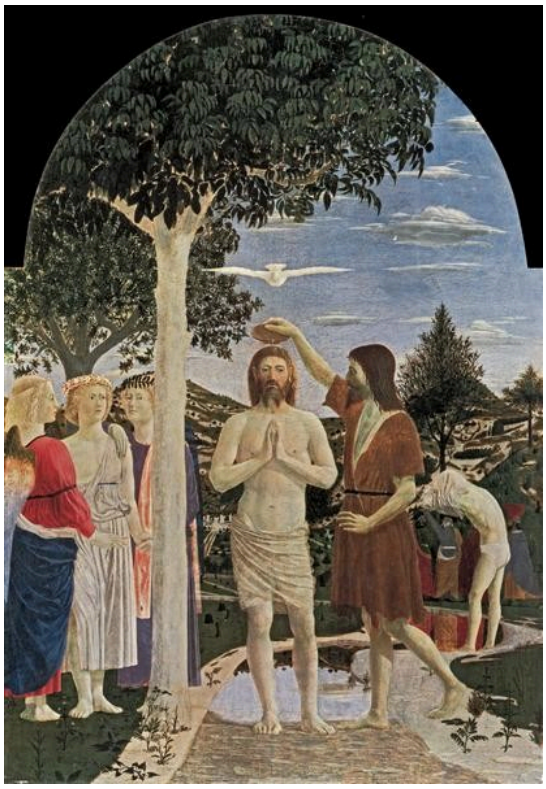
Object source · Open artwork

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# The Baptism of Christ

Piero della Francesca

probably about 1437–1445 · National Gallery



Piero della Francesca. Baptism of Christ. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

John’s small act of pouring water takes place within a notably stable arrangement. Christ’s upright body and the neighbouring pale tree trunk establish parallel forms, while the dove extends its wings above. Stillness does not mean that nothing happens. It gives the modest gesture enough clarity to carry the ceremony.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

# Whistlejacket

George Stubbs

1762 · National Gallery



George Stubbs. Whistlejacket. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Without a rider or a descriptive landscape, the rearing horse has to sustain the entire image. Lifted forelegs, turned head and tail distribute movement through the body. The nearly empty ground sharpens those relations. Stubbs presents an animal with a particular appearance and balance rather than making it a support for a human sitter.

Object source · Open artwork

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# The Execution of Lady Jane Grey

Paul Delaroche

1833 · National Gallery



Paul Delaroche. The Execution of Lady Jane Grey. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Jane cannot see the block she is reaching for. The attendant’s guidance gives the scene a specific action of dependence, surrounded by grief and waiting. Her white dress keeps that vulnerability visible. Delaroche narrows a historical catastrophe to the difficulty of locating the place where her body must be positioned.

Object source · Open artwork

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# A Young Woman Standing at a Virginal

Johannes Vermeer

about 1670-2 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



Johannes Vermeer. A Young Woman standing at a Virginal. Image credit: Johannes Vermeer; Source credit: www.nationalgallery.org.uk : Home : Info. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The woman turns away from the keyboard toward the spectator. Around that slight movement, tiles, pictures and instrument maintain a more regular sequence of rectangles. The contrast gives the turn its force. The interior need not be completely motionless for a small interruption to become its most conspicuous event.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG1383

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# Rain, Steam, and Speed — The Great Western Railway

J. M. W. Turner

1844 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



J. M. W. Turner. Rain, Steam, and Speed - The Great Western Railway. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The bridge gives the locomotive a clear direction while rain and vapour make much of the surrounding land less secure. The engine’s dark front is an approaching point within that instability. Turner lets transport and weather act together on vision: the route remains firm enough to follow even as its setting loses distinct boundaries.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG538

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# Christina of Denmark

Hans Holbein the Younger

c. 1538 · Oil on panel · National Gallery



Hans Holbein the Younger. Christina of Denmark. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/hans-holbein-the-younger/christina-of-denmark · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The black dress occupies most of the figure, with face and joined hands providing limited areas of light. Small distinctions within the dark clothing prevent it from becoming a single flat cut-out. Holbein sustains a full-length presence with few competing accents, making the disposition of the hands especially consequential.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Christ in the House of Mary and Martha

Diego Velázquez

c. 1620 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



Diego Velázquez. Christ in the House of Mary and Martha. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/diego-velazquez/christ-in-the-house-of-mary-and-martha · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The kitchen occupies the foreground with food, vessels and work, while the scene of Christ appears in a smaller opening behind. Their spatial relationship is not entirely straightforward. That uncertainty gives the contrast its importance: the spectator must consider how the labour filling the near space belongs beside the teaching beyond it.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Allegory of Love: Respect

Paolo Veronese

c. 1575 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



Paolo Veronese. Allegory of Love: Respect. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/paolo-veronese/respect · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The armed man’s turn and the child below his extended arm complicate a simple forward approach to the reclining woman. The allegorical title asks for a moral reading, but the movement remains worth examining before it is resolved. Restraint must become visible through bodies that are capable of continuing in another direction.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Bacchanal before a Statue of Pan

Nicolas Poussin

1631 - 1633 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



Nicolas Poussin. Bacchanal Before a Statue of Pan. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/nicolas-poussin/bacchanal-before-a-statue-of-pan-1633 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The linked dancers create a continuous action across the clearing. Raised arms and drapery carry its movement beyond any one body, while nearby figures occupy different relations to the dance. Poussin makes the group readable without reducing exuberance to an assortment of disconnected gestures.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Banks of the Seine at Port-Marly

Alfred Sisley

1875 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



Alfred Sisley. Banks of the Seine at Port Marly. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/alfred-sisley/banks-of-the-seine-at-port-marly-1875 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Trees and pale buildings establish the bank with more stability than their broken reflections possess. The river repeats the scene without producing an equally firm version of it. Sisley lets a familiar place appear in two conditions at once, making the difference between solid edge and moving surface the painting’s quiet subject.

Object source · Open artwork

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# The Building of the Trojan Horse

Giovanni Domenico Tiepolo

1760 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



Giovanni Domenico Tiepolo. Building of the Trojan Horse. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/giovanni-domenico-tiepolo/building-of-the-troyan-horse-1760 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The horse belongs to legend, but the people around it have a practical problem: constructing something much larger than themselves. Tools, ladders and poles make coordinated labour visible. Tiepolo shifts attention from the famous deception to its manufacture, giving an extraordinary object the scale of a job that must be carried out.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Dutch Boats in a Gale

J. M. W. Turner

1801 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



Dutch Boats in a Gale. WikiArt; J. M. W. Turner. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The bright sail leans sharply against dark waves, carrying much of the scene’s danger without a single human face becoming central. A larger vessel remains farther away. The low position gives the near boats little separation from the water around them, making balance an immediate problem rather than a distant spectacle.

Object source · Open artwork

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# The Doge Visiting the Church and Scuola di San Rocco

Canaletto

c. 1735 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery



Canaletto. Feast of San Rocco (The Doge Visiting the Church and Scuola di S. Rocco). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/canaletto/feast-of-san-rocco-the-doge-visiting-the-church-and-scuola-di-s-rocco · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Temporary hangings and displayed pictures add surfaces to the building during the ceremony. The façade supplies a measured structure against which the crowd's smaller irregular movements can remain distinct. Canaletto shows a public occasion through its alteration of a place: the city's architecture accommodates something that will not always be there.

Object source · Open artwork

# Try two different positions

Compare Holbein’s deliberate change of viewpoint with the physical closeness of Caravaggio’s supper, then with the empty setting around *Whistlejacket*. Each establishes a different relation to the spectator. This is a reading sequence rather than a walking route; the National Gallery’s current records should determine which works are available during a visit.

# Further reading

## A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo's Treatise on Painting discusses light, distance, gesture and observation. Those questions provide a historical companion to the different ways of constructing space in this selection.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12